The Coming of Archy and Mehitabel and her Kittens

By Don Marquis

We came into our room earlier than usual in the morning, and discovered a gigantic cockroach jumping about upon the keys. He did not see us, and we watched him. He would climb painfully upon the framework of the machine and cast himself with all his force upon a key, head downward, and his weight and the impact of the blow were just sufficient to operate the machine, one slow letter after another. He could not work the capital letters, and he had a great deal of difficulty operating the mechanism that shifts the paper so that a fresh line may be started. We never saw a cockroach work so hard or perspire so freely in all our lives. After about an hour of this frightfully difficult literary labor he fell to the floor exhausted. Congratulating ourselves that we had left a sheet of paper in the machine the night before so

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that all this work had not been in vain, we made an examination, and this is what we found

INTRODUCTION

In 1916, Marquis introduced a fictional cockroach named "Archy" into his daily newspaper column at the New York Tribune. *Archy's best friend was an alley cat named "Mehitabel," and the two of them shared a series of day-to-day adventures that made* satiric *commentary on daily life in the city during the 1910's and 20's. The Coming of Archy and Mehitable and her Kittens by Don Marquis*

The Coming of Archy

expression is the need of my soul

i was once avers libre bard

but i died and my soul went into the body of a cockroach

it has given me a new outlook upon life

i see things from the under side now

thank you for the apple peelings in the wastepaper

basket but your paste is getting so stale i cant eat it

there is a cat here called mehitabel i wish you would

have removed she nearly ate me the other night why

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dont she catch rats that is what she is supposed to be

for

there is a rat here she should get without delay

most of these rats here are just rats

but this rat is like me he has a human soul in him he used

to be a poet himself

night after night i have written poetry for you

on your typewriter

and this big brute of a rat who used to be a poet comes

out of his hole when it is done

and reads it and sniffs at it

he is jealous of my poetry

he used to make fun of it when we were both human he

was a punk poet himself

and after he has read it he sneers

and then he eats it

i wish you would have mehitabel kill that rat

or get a cat that is onto her job

and i will write you a series of poems showing how things

look to a cockroach

that rats name is Freddy

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the next time freddy dies i hope he wont be a rat

but something smaller i hope i will be a rat

in the next transmigration and freddy a cockroach

i will teach him to sneer at my poetry then

archy

TRANSITION

Mehitabel has a weakness for bad-boy tomcats and pals around with other up-to-no-good street cats. Archy repeatedly tries to encourage Mehitabel to clean up her act and get a job as a nice house kitten where she can be taken care of. But Mehitabel is taking no advice from Archy . . . afterall, she's her own woman, errr. Cat. . . . Mehitabel and her Kittens

Mehitabel and her Kittens

well boss

mehitabel the cat

has reappeared in her old haunts with a

flock of kittens

three of them this time

archy she said to me yesterday

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the life of a female artist is continually hampered what
in hell have i done to deserve all these kittens
i look back on my life and it seems to me to be just one
damned kitten after another
i am a dancer archy and my only prayer is to be allowed
to give my best to my art
but just as i feel
that i am succeeding
in my life work
along comes another batch
of these damned kittens
it is not archy
that i am shy on mother love god knows i care for
the sweet little things
curse them
but am i never to be allowed to live my own life
i have purposely avoided matrimony in the interests
of the higher life
but i might just
as well have been a domestic slave for all the freedom
i have gained

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i hope none of them
gets run over by
an automobile
my heart would bleed
if anything happened
to them and i found it out
but it isn t fair archy
it isn t fair
these damned tom cats have all the fun and freedom
if i was like some of these green eyed feline vamps i
know i would simply walk out on the bunch of them and
let them shift for themselves but i am not that kind
archy i am full of mother love my kindness has always
been my curse
a tender heart is the cross i bear self sacrifice always
and forever is my motto damn them
i will make a home
for the sweet innocent
little things .
unless of course providence
in his wisdom should remove them they are living

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just now in an abandoned garbage can just behind
a made over stable in greenwich village and if it rained
into the can before i could
get back and rescue them
i am afraid the little
dears might drown
it makes me shudder just
to think of it
of course if i were a family cat they would probably
be drowned anyhow sometimes i think
the kinder thing would be
for me to carry the
sweet little things
over to the river
and drop them in myself
but a mother's love archy
is so unreasonable
something always prevents me these terrible
conflicts are always
presenting themselves
to the artist

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the eternal struggle
between art and life archy
is something fierce
yes something fierce
my what a dramatic
life i have lived
one moment up the next
moment down again
but always gay archy always gay and always the lady too
in spite of hell
well boss it will
be interesting to note
just how mehitabel
works out her present problem a dark mystery still
broods over the manner
in which the former
family of three kittens disappeared
one day she was talking to me of the kittens
and the next day when i asked her about them
she said innocently
what kittens

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interrogation point

and that was all

i could ever get out

of her on the subject

we had a heavy rain

right after she spoke to me but probably that garbage

can leaks and so the kittens

have not yet

been drowned

archy

SOURCE INFORMATION

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